

The Long Reach of Sponsorship: How Fan Isolation and Identification Jointly Shape Sponsorship Performance

Marc Mazodier, Conor M. Henderson, and Joshua T. Beck

Abstract

Globalization and technology have expanded the reach of sports teams, giving brand sponsors new opportunities to engage and build relationships in real time with fans outside a team's home market. This research investigates the role of fan isolation, or the experience of feeling separated from the team community, in shaping sponsorship effectiveness. The authors posit that such isolation increases the desire to affiliate with the team community, which can increase preferences for team-linked brands. However, the effect of isolation on sponsor performance depends on the strength of fan identification. Isolation increases strong fans' desire to affiliate with the team community, thereby enhancing sponsorship performance; by contrast, isolation causes weak fans to avoid team-linked brands. Two field studies and four quasi experiments conducted across three countries ($N = 1,412$) confirm these predictions. Isolated strong fans exhibit increased recall, attitudes, purchase intentions, and word of mouth for sponsors, while isolated weak fans display the opposite effects. For brand managers, the proposed framework reveals whether isolated fans provide the best or worst returns on their sponsorships.

Keywords

brand performance, identification, isolation, sponsorship

Online supplement: <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022242918807673>

Many fans live or spend time outside their favorite team's home market (Collins et al. 2016; DeSarbo, Blank, and Kim 2017). In the United States, out-of-market fans can account for the bulk of nonticket revenue (Fain 2013). Brand sponsors are beginning to recognize these fans when drafting their sponsorship initiatives. For example, Chevrolet's \$560 million sponsorship of the British soccer team Manchester United specifically targeted team fans who live in other countries (Baxter 2014). Indeed, as much as 80% of Premier League fans, such as those of Manchester United, live outside the United Kingdom (Premier League 2012). These examples highlight the market potential of out-of-market sponsorship. Thus, the purpose of this research is to understand how the experience of out-of-market fans shapes sponsorship performance to determine which fans provide the best return on sponsorship.

Brand sponsorship aims to leverage fans' relationship with the sponsored team to drive customers through the purchase funnel from brand awareness to consideration, attitudes, purchase, and word-of-mouth (WOM) (Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy 2005). However, industry experts estimate that as much as one-third of sponsorship budgets are wasted (Jacobs, Jain, and Surana 2014). For example, only 50% of television viewers

can recall a sponsor of the National Football League (NFL) (Spanberg 2012), and even fans who regularly attend games are unable to recall most brand sponsors (Wakefield, Becker-Olsen, and Cornwell 2007).

The present research adopts a fresh perspective on sponsorship by positing that sponsorship effectiveness depends partly on where strong (vs. weak) fans are situated relative to other fans. This perspective is increasingly relevant as advances in location-based advertising platforms coupled with a more globally distributed media environment allow managers to target audiences according to the combination of their real-time location and personal interests; this raises "the issue of getting marketing 'right' in real time" (Marketing Science Institute 2016, p. 6), especially for personal interest-based sponsorships.

Marc Mazodier is Associate Professor of Marketing, Zayed University, and Affiliate Professor, Kedge Business School (email: marcmazodier@gmail.com). Conor M. Henderson is Assistant Professor of Marketing, Lundquist College of Business, University of Oregon (email: conorh@uoregon.edu). Joshua T. Beck is Assistant Professor of Marketing, Lundquist College of Business, University of Oregon (email: jbeck2@uoregon.edu).

Drawing on theories of identity and affiliation (Ethier and Deaux 1994; Mehra, Kilduff, and Bass 1998), we predict that fan isolation, or the experience of feeling separated from the team community, generates an affiliation motive that triggers different responses, depending on the level of fan identification. In isolating contexts, strong fans should pursue team-based affiliation, whereas weak fans should pursue alternative means of affiliation with others in their immediate social environment. These distinct affiliation strategies result in isolated strong fans being more receptive to brands that support the team (“doubling-down” effects of enhanced recall, attitudes, purchase intentions, and WOM) and isolated weak fans avoiding brands that support the team (“desertion” effects).

The objective of this research is to investigate the interplay of fan isolation and identification in the sponsorship domain using a multimethod approach across three countries and three sports. With natural variance from field surveys of actual fans, Studies 1a and 1b demonstrate that brand sponsorship performance depends on the interaction between the level of fan isolation and identification. In a survey of Premier League fans, Study 1a finds that the accurate recall rate of a team’s brand sponsor is greater among more (vs. less) isolated strong fans (68% vs. 50%) but lesser among more (vs. less) isolated weak fans (31% vs. 37%).¹ Study 1b shows a similar pattern of effects on performance among Lakers’ fans; among strong fans, isolation results in a 22% increase in both brand sponsor purchase intentions and WOM, while among weak fans, isolation results in an 8% decline in purchase intentions and a 9% decline in WOM. Thus, in natural settings, fan identification polarizes the effects of isolation on sponsorship performance.

Through quasi experiments in Studies 2 and 3, we manipulate the feeling of isolation to validate the real-world findings from Study 1. Study 2a also demonstrates a key role of sponsorship, finding no effects on performance when the brand is not presented as a team sponsor. Offering a key managerial insight, Study 2b further reveals that just one exposure to the brand sponsorship for isolated strong fans is as effective as multiple exposures to the brand sponsor for all fans. Study 3 replicates these effects and confirms the key mediating role of affiliation. That is, isolation increases affiliation motives for all fans, but the effects of affiliation on brand sponsor performance vary by fan identification, such that affiliation increases attitudes toward a brand sponsor among strong fans but decreases it among weak fans. Furthermore, this pattern of effects extends to fans’ choice of gift card. Finally, in the “Managerial Implementation” section, we demonstrate how a brand manager can use the proposed framework in a targeted Facebook campaign.

Together, these investigations provide three primary contributions to marketing theory and practice. First, the findings provide insights to brand managers wanting to reach mass-market, global consumers through sports sponsorships. Sports

are unique in their broad appeal to live audiences (Thompson 2016), leading to substantial increases in spending on sports sponsorships (annual growth of 4.3% vs. 2.6% for general brand advertising) and predictions that these will soon exceed \$16 billion annually in North America alone (IEG 2017). Yet investors remain skeptical; many sponsorship announcements lead to negative abnormal stock returns (Mazodier and Rezaee 2013). Our framework reveals which fans are more receptive to brand sponsorships; that is, strong fans who are relatively isolated, either permanently or temporarily, provide the best returns on sponsorships. These findings support the sports industry shift to out-of-market sponsorship.

Second, extant theories of consumer affiliation suggest that isolation increases people’s desire to connect with in-group (e.g., team-sponsoring) brands (Lastovicka and Sirianni 2011). Our research demonstrates a critical role of identification in shaping these responses to isolation. Thus, whereas prior work reveals key differences between in-group and out-group influences (Berger and Heath 2008; White and Dahl 2006), we identify the considerable variation across in-group members in their pursuit of group-linked brands, explained by their level of identification. While this research is situated in sports, we expect the constructs and theoretical relationships to extend to any consumer community.

Third, this work complements growing research on the role of geographic proximity in determining marketing outcomes (Andrews et al. 2016; Meyners et al. 2017). Across the studies, we examine the pivotal impact of fan isolation, from geographic displacement or social experience, on sponsorship effectiveness.

Literature Review

This work bridges the research streams of fan isolation and fan identification. Importantly, this research aims to advance the sponsorship strategy literature by understanding the joint effects of fan isolation and identification on sponsorship performance at the individual fan level. We first briefly review sponsorship as a key marketing strategy and then discuss foundational research in each stream and the contribution of the current research.

Sponsorship as a Key Marketing Strategy

Sponsorship is an investment, in cash or kind, in an event, person, or idea, and sponsorship marketing refers to the organization and implementation of marketing activities to build and communicate an association with a sponsored entity (Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy 2005; Mazodier and Merunka 2012). A large body of sponsorship research provides a foundation for crafting an effective sponsorship strategy. By leveraging fans’ relationships with sponsored entities (e.g., teams), sponsorship generates brand awareness through brand exposure, establishes a brand–team connection, and facilitates the transfer of attitudes and associations (e.g., image) from the team to the brand with little cognitive mediation (Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy

¹ These distinctions are based on model estimates at plus or minus one standard deviation from mean levels of fan isolation and identification.

2005; Gwinner and Eaton 1999; Mazodier and Merunka 2012). Sponsor–team fit (i.e., congruity) facilitates these processes (Cornwell et al. 2006; Simmons and Becker-Olsen 2006). Variables contributing to fans’ positive view of the sponsored entity, such as event involvement and self-congruity with the event, also predict enhanced sponsorship performance (Mazodier and Merunka 2012; Walraven, Bijmolt, and Koning 2014). In addition to fit-and-transfer models, an emerging line of research situated in attribution theory shows the importance of inference making about the sponsorship itself. Fans infer motives for the sponsorship based on observable features, such as whether a brand’s headquarters are located near the team, and fans favor sponsorships that appear more authentic (Simmons and Becker-Olsen 2006; Woisetschläger, Backhaus, and Cornwell 2017).

Critically, although prior sponsorship research has examined sponsorship performance in relation to situational variables (e.g., geographic location; Pu and James 2017) and individual variables (e.g., fan identification; Grohs 2016; Madrigal 2000), little is known about how these variables may interact, though recent work suggests an interaction; for example, Scheinbaum, Krishen, and Lough (2017) find that fan identification is more positively related to liking and recommending a cycling event among fans who traveled farther to attend the event. We posit that this effect likely stems from the increased affiliation motives of isolated strong fans. Next, we review these separate research streams and then develop a theoretical model for how the two constructs interact to determine sponsorship effectiveness.

How Fan Isolation Shapes Sponsorship Effectiveness

Isolation refers to the psychological separation of the self from others (Cacioppo, Fowler, and Christakis 2009), and we define “fan isolation” as a fan’s feeling of separation from the team community. We use this term to capture the underlying psychological state that can emanate from social situations that cause fans to feel separated from their team communities (i.e., teams and other fans). For example, prior work has examined how geographically distant fans (e.g., Chinese residents who are National Basketball Association [NBA] fans) feel a sense of separation and also vicarious achievement when watching NBA games, despite having never lived in the United States (Pu and James 2017). Relatedly, work shows how displaced fans, or those who have moved away from their team community and now reside in an out-of-market location, feel a sense of isolation that causes them to engage more in online team-based communities (Stavros et al. 2014). Fans may also feel a sense of temporary separation from the team community when its focus is on rivals. A person can be physically close to others but psychologically distant, due to differences in group membership (Forehand, Deshpandé, and Reed 2002). Previous work shows that merely thinking about rivals can evoke a sense of separation, which can result in motives such as holding more favorable attitudes toward the in-group fan community and derogating out-group (rival) brand sponsors (Bergkvist 2012;

Grohs, Reisinger, and Woisetschläger 2015). Thus, fan isolation, which occurs for a variety of reasons, can increase people’s desires to connect with the fan community.

How Fan Identification Shapes Sponsorship Effectiveness

The concept of identification is rooted in Tajfel and Turner’s (1979) model of in-group membership, which explains the process of self-categorization in a group and the emotional significance of sharing in that group’s experiences. In this research, we broadly define “fan identification” as the extent to which a person self-categorizes as a fan of a given team and his or her generalized sense of emotional significance and symbolic meaning derived from belonging to the team’s fan community (Cameron 2004; Funk, Ridinger, and Moorman 2004; Mael and Ashforth 1992). Identification does not require physical presence; a team community can be imagined, similar to the concepts of “imagined community” and “imagined collective” (Reysen and Branscombe 2010).

Even within a particular team, some fans identify more intensely than others; this difference is captured by the level or strength of identification, which refers to the chronic sense of connection one experiences with a given social group (Cameron 2004; Dalton and Huang 2014; Forehand, Deshpandé, and Reed 2002). Notably, identification is not binary (fan vs. nonfan) but instead falls along a continuum (nonfan vs. fan identification levels). We examine the differences in the level of identification among people who indicate they are fans of a given team. For simplicity, we use strong and weak fans as shorthand to differentiate between fans with more and less intense levels of identification, respectively.

The variance in fan identification can explain fan behavior over time. Both strong and weak fans may enjoy the benefits of their fan identity (e.g., easy conversation starter, source of entertainment), but weak fans likely find it easier to avoid thinking about the team when they are among a nonfan out-group. Strong fans are prouder of the team’s achievements and, as a consequence, are more reliable advocates and consumers of team-related experiences and memorabilia (Decrop and Derbaix 2010). Fan identification can be a source of personal self-esteem, as strong fans derive more personal validation from team achievements (Hirt et al. 1992). Conversely, weak or “fair-weather” fans do not regard the team as much of a central or enduring aspect of their self-concept and are less likely to attend games when the team has a losing record (Oishi et al. 2007).

Fan identification is a critical determinant of sponsorship performance. For example, strong (vs. weak) fans are more likely to purchase sponsor brands, especially when such purchasing is the norm in the team’s fan community (Madrigal 2000). Strong fans are also more likely to see their team’s image in the brand sponsor, by way of image transfer (Cornwell, Weeks, and Roy 2005; Grohs 2016), and will purchase sponsor brands as a way of demonstrating commitment to the team community (Lings and Owen 2007). Together, this research supports the notion that strong fans use brand sponsors

as a means to build a sense of connection with the team. Thus, central to our research aim, it is important to understand how strong (vs. weak) fans react to isolation.

A Theory of Fan Affiliation in Out-of-Market Sponsorship

How do fan isolation and identification jointly affect sponsorship effectiveness? In this section, we build a contingent affiliation model for sponsorship to understand the combined effects of these key constructs. The two streams of research presented previously imply that the positive effects of fan isolation and identification are additive. Conversely, we propose that the joint effects are multiplicative and that this interactive effect stems from fans' differential responses to isolation.

Isolation Increases the Desire to Affiliate

Fans of a given team will find themselves, at some point in time, in isolating social contexts, whether from the presence of rival fans or the absence of in-group fans when the focal fans are temporarily or permanently outside the team's home market. In such situations, belongingness theory predicts that the sense of isolation will trigger an increased desire to affiliate (Baumeister and Leary 1995; Mead et al. 2011). For example, isolated fans might turn to online communities to satisfy their affiliation motives (Stavros et al. 2014). In addition, fan isolation might encourage positive attention to brand sponsors. As prior work has demonstrated, isolation increases the pursuit of nonhuman (e.g., brand) relationships (Lastovicka and Sirianni 2011), and sponsor brands are prime relational targets because they represent a meaningful connection with the team community (Herrmann, Kacha, and Derbaix 2016). Consider, for example, a strong fan of the Los Angeles Lakers who lives in Chicago. When presented with an ad for Wish (a retail brand sponsoring the Lakers), this fan may embrace the brand to satisfy a desire to affiliate with the team community. Fans living in Los Angeles, surrounded by other fans, temper one another's desire for affiliation. Thus, fan isolation should increase the desire to affiliate, which may lead to improved sponsorship performance. We argue, however, that chronic differences in fan identification determine reactions to an increased desire to affiliate.

Identification Shapes Reactions to an Increased Desire to Affiliate

Fan response to isolation likely varies on the level of fan identification. That is, across all fans, isolation should increase affiliation motives. Two paths are available to satisfy these enhanced affiliation motives: (1) bolstering fan identity (doubling-down effect), which would entail actively seeking a connection with the team community, and (2) suppressing fan identity (desertion effect), which would entail actively avoiding team-linked content, which in turn frees fans to affiliate with proximal others in ways unrelated to their preferred

sports team. We predict that fans' level or strength of identification determines which pathway they pursue.

Oyserman (2008) defines strong identifiers as schematic; group membership is integral to their sense of self. Thus, bolstering identification should help them overcome social isolation (Pratt 1998). We predict that fan isolation increases the desire of strong fans to affiliate with the team community and therefore increases their receptiveness to team-linked content, as suggested by belongingness theory. By contrast, weak identifiers are aschematic; group membership is not integral to their sense of self and is merely a fact. We argue that weak fans will feel a sense of separation from their home community when isolated but will be able to suppress their fan identity and choose not to satisfy the desire to affiliate with the team. Weak fans will view the team as an obstacle to building relationships with proximal others.

In support of this theory, research in cultural identity domains indicates that the strength of the home culture identity determines whether a person bolsters or avoids activities and groups related to that home culture. Strong identifiers pursue home culture-related activities, while weak identifiers actively avoid such activities and find other means of affiliating (Ethier and Deaux 1994). Similarly, we expect that strong fans in isolating contexts pursue brands linked to their team (i.e., brand sponsors), while weak fans in isolating contexts try to avoid them. This predicted fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction effect on sponsor effectiveness stems from an affiliation-based process. Thus, we hypothesize the following:

H₁: There is a fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction effect on sponsor effectiveness, such that (a) for strong fans, isolation enhances brand sponsor performance (recall, attitude, purchase intention, and WOM) while (b) for weak fans, isolation reduces brand sponsor performance.

H₂: Affiliation motives mediate the fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction effect on sponsor performance.

Empirical Overview

Three sets of studies test our hypotheses. Studies 1a and 1b examine the prediction that isolation yields differential effects on sponsorship performance as a function of fan identification, using field data from Premier League (Study 1a) and NBA (Study 1b) fans. Study 2a employs experimental methods to confirm the causal role of isolation in producing the focal interaction when a brand advertisement features the sponsorship but not when the sponsorship information is absent. Study 2b replicates these effects and tests whether multiple exposures to the advertisement with sponsorship improve performance for all fans (i.e., boundary condition). In Study 3, we test whether desire to affiliate mediates the fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction effect on sponsor brand performance. We repeat Study 3 with another sponsor and show that isolation almost doubles the percentage of strong fans who choose a gift card for the sponsor brand over its competitor. Figure 1 provides an

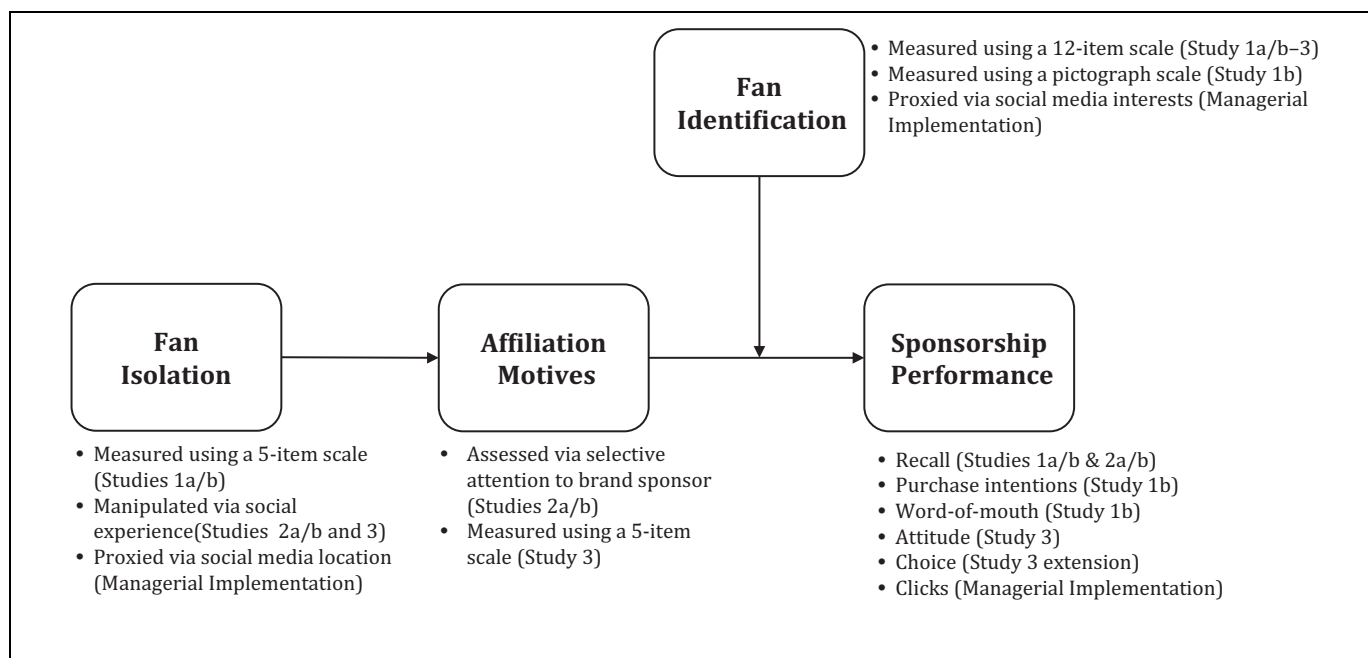


Figure 1. Conceptual model and operationalization of key constructs across studies.

overview of our conceptual model, as well as the operationalization of focal constructs and key performance outcomes.

Study 1: Field Data

Study 1 tests the central prediction that fans' reception to a brand sponsor will vary as a function of fan isolation and identification. Across two contexts, we observe the level of fans' isolation and identification and test sponsor performance as their recall of their team's main sponsor (Study 1a: fans of Premier League teams) or their recall, purchase intentions, and WOM of their team's main sponsor (Study 1b: fans of the Los Angeles Lakers).

Study 1a: Method

Sample and design. Three hundred eighty-nine fans of a Premier League team in the United Kingdom (43.4% female, average age 43 years) completed an online survey after being invited to participate by a marketing research firm that we hired. The panel company recruited only football fans. The fans were naturally dispersed geographically, such that some fans lived near many other fans of the same team and others did not. Respondents selected their favorite Premier League team and then completed measures of isolation and identification. As the focal dependent variable, respondents were asked to recall the primary brand sponsor of their team, which prominently appears on the athletes' jerseys. Finally, respondents provided demographic information.

Identification. Fans selected their favorite team, and then we assessed the level of fan identification with Cameron's (2004) scale, which we adapted to reflect fan identity.

Respondents indicated their level of agreement with 12 items on a seven-point scale (1 = "strongly disagree," and 7 = "strongly agree"; $\alpha = .82$): "I have a lot in common with other [team name] fans"; "I feel strong ties to other [team name] fans"; "I find it difficult to form a bond with other [team name] fans" (reversed); "I don't feel a sense of being 'connected' with other [team name] fans" (reversed); "I often think about being a [team name] fan"; "Overall, being a [team name] fan has very little to do with how I feel about myself" (reversed); "In general, being a [team name] fan is an important part of my self-image"; "The fact that I am a [team name] fan rarely enters my mind" (reversed); "In general, I am glad to be a [team name] fan"; "I often regret that I am a [team name] fan" (reversed); "I don't feel good about being a [team name] fan" (reversed); and "Generally, I feel good when I think about myself as a [team name] fan."

Sponsor brand recall. Respondents answered the question, "What is the jersey sponsor of the [team name] football club (i.e., the brand displayed on the football shirt like Pirelli for the Inter Milan football club)?" We coded the responses as accurate recall (1) or inaccurate (0). Recall followed the measurement of fan identification, to ensure that a recall failure did not influence self-reported identification.

Isolation. Respondents indicated their city of residence. Next, they were instructed to "think about your local geographic community and the people you live with in [city of residence]." We measured isolation with a five-item seven-point scale (1 = "strongly disagree," and 7 = "strongly agree"; $\alpha = .78$): "My community supports the [team]" (reversed), "My community supports a different team," "My community mainly ignores the [team]," "My community dislikes the [team]," and "The

Table 1. Study 1a and 1b Descriptive Statistics and Correlations.

Study 1a: British Premier League													
Variables	M	SD	α	1.	2.	3.	4.	5.	6.	7.			
1. Sponsor Brand Recall	.61	.49		1									
2. Identification	4.49	.89	.82	.17	1								
3. Isolation	4.26	1.16	.78	.00	-.27	1							
4. Age	42.66	13.6		-.04	.02	.03	1						
5. Gender (Female)	.43	.50		-.11	-.17	-.07	-.06	1					
6. Education	3.37	1.21		.05	-.18	.03	-.17	.09	1				
7. Length of Residence	24.87	17.5		.05	.10	-.15	.46	.01	-.18	1			
Study 1b: Los Angeles Lakers													
Variables	M	SD	α	1.	2.	3.	4.	5.	6.	7.	8.	9.	10.
1. Sponsor Brand Recall	.40	.49		1									
2. Sponsor Brand Purchase Intentions	4.58	1.66		.23	1								
3. Sponsor Brand Word of Mouth	4.51	1.60		.23	.96	1							
4. Identification	4.993	.89	.82	.01	.29	.26	1						
5. Isolation	3.46	1.28	.82	.14	.02	.01	-.35	1					
6. Age	42.23	13.82		-.15	-.18	-.14	-.11	-.17	1				
7. Gender (Female)	0.412	0.5		-.02	-.04	-.05	-.11	.11	-.34	1			
8. Education	3.42	.93		.06	.00	.00	.01	-.07	.18	-.22	1		
9. Length of Residence	22.44	15.56		.00	.03	.04	-.07	-.14	.43	-.16	-.05	1	
10. Purchase Intentions Competitors	5.189	1.1		.01	.49	.52	.22	-.07	-.14	.02	.05	-.07	1
11. Word of Mouth Competitors	5.113	1.13		.00	.51	.54	.29	-.10	-.13	.00	.02	-.08	.92

Notes: M is mean, SD is standard deviation, and α is Cronbach's alpha. Significant correlations ($p < .05$) are in bold font.

average citizen of [city of residence] is very different from the [team's] community of supporters." Table 1 reports the descriptive statistics and correlations.

Study 1a: Results

To understand how fan isolation and identification jointly shape sponsor brand performance, we submitted sponsor brand recall (1/0) to a logistic regression with isolation, identification, and their interaction as predictors (see Table 2). Beyond fan isolation and identification, many other factors related to each team, each fan, and each sponsor can affect a fan's ability to recall the current sponsor of a favorite team. We explicitly control for unobserved factors that might correlate with each team-brand combination (through team fixed effects) and personal characteristics of age, gender, education, and length of residence in the community (Walraven, Bijmolt, and Koning 2014). The results remain stable and significant whether we control for these factors or not.

In support of H_1 , the key interaction between isolation and identification was positive and significant ($b = .24$, $p < .05$). We probed the interaction using a floodlight analysis (Spiller et al. 2013) of the simple effect of fan isolation at varying levels of identification. As the results indicate, fan isolation had a positive and significant ($p < .05$) effect on recall for fans in the top 22% of our sample in terms of identification (Johnson-Neyman [JN] point at identification scores equal to or greater than 5.09). For the weakest 1% of fans in our sample, evidence at the 90% confidence interval (CI) shows that fan isolation

was associated with worse recall of the sponsor (JN point = 2.27). Figure 2 displays these estimated effects.

Study 1b: Method

In Study 1b, we surveyed fans of the Los Angeles Lakers to (1) conceptually replicate Study 1a's results, (2) examine additional sponsorship performance outcomes, (3) hold the brand sponsor constant, and (4) implement a recontact method to insert temporal distance between measurement of fan identification, isolation, and our focal dependent variables. At the time of the survey, the Lakers had recently added a sponsor brand (e-commerce retailer Wish) to the team's uniforms. We examine the effectiveness of this sponsorship halfway through the 2017–2018 season, the first season in which NBA jersey sponsorship was permitted.

The marketing research firm from Study 1a conducted a two-wave online survey of Los Angeles Lakers fans. The firm aimed to recruit half the sample from within the Los Angeles metropolitan area and half from outside it. Respondents were screened using three questions: "Are you interested in the NBA?" "Please, select your favorite NBA team"; and "From the following list, who is your all-time favorite Los Angeles Lakers' player?" Respondents were invited to complete the entire survey if they selected "yes," "Los Angeles Lakers," and a player who actually played for the Lakers. In the first wave, 291 fans completed the same fan isolation ($\alpha = .84$) and identification ($\alpha = .83$) measures as in Study 1a. As an alternative indicator of identification, they also completed a single-item,

Table 2. Study 1 Estimations Results: Sponsorship Performance for Premier League (Study 1a) and the Lakers (Study 1b).

	Study 1a			Study 1b								
	Brand Recall			Brand Recall			Purchase Intentions		Word of Mouth			
	Estimate	p-Value		Estimate	p-Value		Estimate	p-Value		Estimate	p-Value	
Primary Predictors												
Identification	.57	(.15)	<.001	.13	(.23)	.571	.43	(.15)	.005	.28	(.14)	.050
Isolation	.32	(.14)	.025	.53	(.21)	.013	.38	(.13)	.003	.38	(.12)	.002
Identification × Isolation	.24	(.11)	.020	.38	(.18)	.030	.29	(.10)	.006	.30	(.10)	.003
Controls												
Age	−.01	(.01)	.168	−.04	(.02)	.022	−.02	(.01)	.031	−.02	(.01)	.077
Gender (Female)	−.38	(.24)	.112	−.27	(.41)	.509	−.23	(.26)	.373	−.21	(.25)	.388
Education	.20	(.10)	.046	.29	(.21)	.169	.04	(.13)	.790	.05	(.13)	.708
Length of Residence	.02	(.01)	.023	.01	(.01)	.269	.02	(.01)	.060	.02	(.01)	.052
Ratings of Competitor Brands							.73	(.12)	<.001	.78	(.11)	<.001
Team Fixed Effects		Included										
Intercept	−.64	(.96)	.507	.27	(.97)	.782	1.86	(.89)	.039	1.21	(.83)	.149
Model Fit												
R-square								.34			.39	
Deviance (−2 log likelihood)		453.9			170.0			462.1			446.4	
AIC		507.9			186.0			482.14			466.4	
BIC		614.9			209.3			511.27			495.6	
Likelihood ratio chi-square test	65.45	(df = 26)		13.57	(df = 7)		60.33	(df = 8)		66.51	(df = 8)	
		<.001			.059			<.001			<.001	

image-based pictograph measure consisting of a series of increasingly overlapping circles representing the fan and the team (Bergami and Bagozzi 2000).

One week later, the marketing research firm recontacted respondents to invite them to complete a seemingly unrelated survey on e-commerce brands. One hundred thirty-six respondents completed this second wave of the survey (41.2% women, average age 42 years, 40.4% living outside the Los Angeles metropolitan area). Respondents completed measures of purchase intention and WOM for four e-commerce brands: Wish (Lakers' sponsor), Rakuten, Amazon.com, and eBay. They rated purchase intentions and WOM using single items ("I will purchase products from [brand]" and "I will recommend [brand] to my friends to buy products online") on seven-point scales (1 = "strongly disagree," and 7 = "strongly agree"). Then, they were asked to recall the jersey sponsor for the Los Angeles Lakers, which provided a measure of sponsor brand recall, which we coded as a dichotomous outcome (1 = accurate recall, 0 = inaccurate or not recall). Finally, respondents provided demographic information. Table 1 reports the descriptive statistics and correlations.

Study 1b: Results

Sponsor purchase intention and WOM. For the sponsorship performance outcomes of sponsor brand purchase intentions and WOM, we conducted ordinary least squares regressions with isolation, identification, and their interaction as predictors. We also controlled for purchase intention and WOM for the other e-commerce companies (Rakuten, Amazon, and eBay) and gender, age, and education to account for baseline variance

in consumers' attitudes toward and familiarity and comfort with e-commerce. Consistent with the pattern of results from Study 1a (for model estimates, see Table 2), the key interaction between isolation and identification was positive and significant for purchase intentions ($b = .29, p < .01$) and WOM ($b = .30, p < .01$). Floodlight analysis revealed that fan isolation had a significant, positive effect ($p < .05$) on purchase intention and WOM among strong fans at the top 38% of the sample (JN point = 5.25). Conversely, for relatively weak fans, fan isolation corresponded to a marginally significant, negative effect ($p < .10$) on sponsor purchase intention (JN point = 3.36; bottom 2% of sample) and a significant, negative effect ($p < .05$) on WOM (JN point = 3.22).

Sponsor brand recall. As in Study 1a, we used logistic regression to analyze the interactive effects of fan isolation and identification on sponsor brand recall. The interaction between fan isolation and identification was positive and significant ($b = .38, p < .05$). Floodlight analysis revealed that fan isolation had a significant, positive effect ($p < .05$) on sponsor brand recall among strong fans at the top 33% of the sample (JN point = 5.35).

Alternative measure of identification. We repeated each analysis using the scores for identification from the image-based pictograph measure of identification (Bergami and Bagozzi 2000), which correlated with our main identification scale at .48 ($p < .001$). The results were stable; the key interaction between isolation and identification was positive and significant for sponsor brand recall ($b = .19, p < .05$), purchase intentions ($b = .11, p < .05$), and WOM ($b = .08, p < .10$).

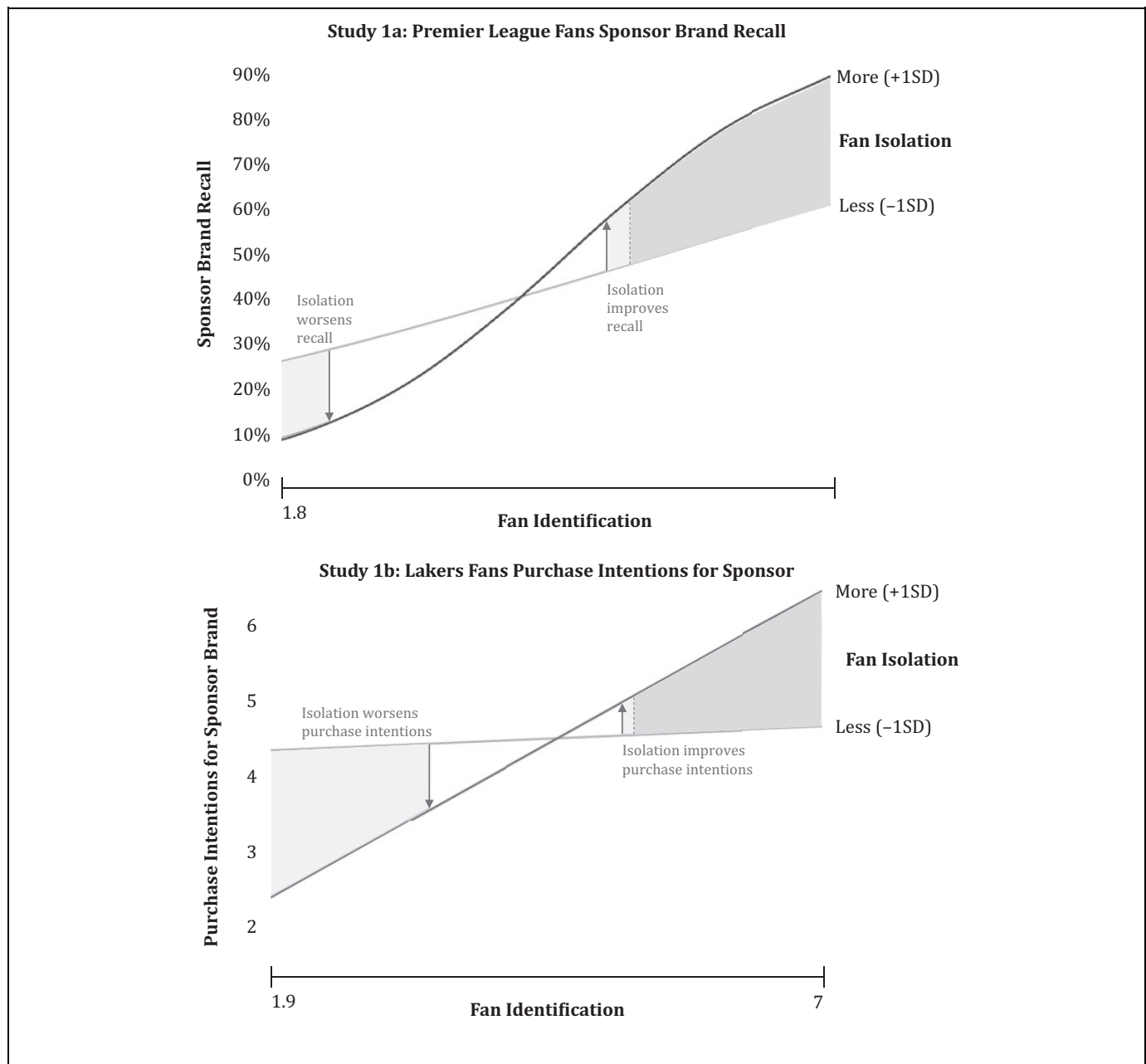


Figure 2. Study 1: Estimated effects of fan identification $\times$ isolation on sponsor performance.

Notes: 1.8 and 1.9 were the minimum observed value for fan identification in the Study 1a and 1b samples. Shading represents regions at which effect of isolation is significant at 90% (light gray) and 95% (dark gray) confidence levels.

Discussion

Studies 1a and 1b provide real-world, managerially relevant evidence that isolated strong fans respond most favorably to brand sponsors. Among Premier League fans, the model estimates that unaided sponsor brand recall among the strongest fans (identification = 7) is 28 percentage points higher in more isolated than less isolated contexts (isolation ± 1 standard deviation). Similarly, among the strongest Lakers fans, purchase intentions are 39% higher and WOM is 43% higher in more than less isolated contexts.

As a caveat, these results rely on naturally occurring variance, which reduces confidence in the causal role of isolation in sponsorship performance. Furthermore, the finding that isolation evokes worse recall, purchase intentions, and WOM among the weakest identifiers could be due to their fewer exposures to the sponsor's logo on team jerseys; that is, an isolated fan is less likely to encounter other fans wearing the team's jersey in public. To increase confidence in the causal role of fan isolation and explicitly vary exposures to sponsor-based advertising, we conduct quasi experiments that hold the

team and brand constant while manipulating fan isolation and the number of exposures to a sponsor-linked advertisement.

Study 2: Experimental Confirmation and Extension

With the experimental design in Study 2, our goal is to confirm the key fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction across several managerially relevant advertising conditions. In Study 2a, we examine performance as unaided recall for a brand after just one exposure to a brand advertisement in which the brand is (vs. is not) presented as a sponsor. The key interaction should hold only in the sponsorship condition. In Study 2b, we test this same single-exposure condition against an alternative condition with two exposures to the sponsorship advertisement. If the fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction operates through selective interest in the sponsor brand, emanating from affiliation motives, the interaction should be present with a single exposure but overrun in the two-exposure condition. Testing these effects also enables us to provide managerial insights into the efficacy of brand sponsorship promotions across single and repeat exposures.

Study 2a: Method

Sample and design. Both Studies 2a and 2b followed an identical procedure. First, 288 fans of Paris Saint Germain (PSG), a professional soccer team based in France, completed an initial online screening survey after being invited to participate by the same marketing research firm we employed for Study 1. The marketing research firm contacted soccer fans who followed PSG but lived in “la province” (i.e., outside Paris).²

Second, 1 week later, the marketing research firm recontacted the same respondents to complete a seemingly unrelated online survey for marketers soliciting informants’ views on the new layout of a national newspaper. This temporal separation minimizes the possibility that self-reporting interfered with the isolation manipulation. Two hundred ten respondents completed this survey (39.1% women, average age 39 years); we randomly assigned them to a 2 (fan isolation: more vs. less isolated) $\times$ 2 (sponsorship: present vs. absent) between-subjects experimental design. We manipulated fan isolation in the cover story of the second survey and manipulated the advertisement in the newspaper. After reading the newspaper, respondents provided open-ended feedback about the new layout and also reported the names of any brands that advertised therein, which we coded as an indication of sponsor brand recall. Finally, respondents described themselves and completed measures to indicate the salience of their fan identity, before providing demographic information.

Identification. As in Study 1, we assessed identification using Cameron’s (2004) scale. Fans completed the 12-item scale for PSG fan identification ($\alpha = .87$).

Isolation. In the low- (high-) isolation condition, respondents were told that the marketing research firm was seeking evaluations of the newspaper from 500 (50) citizens of “la province” and 50 (500) citizens of Paris (adapted from Dalton and Huang 2014). At the end of the survey, as a manipulation check, respondents indicated whether they felt isolated during the study, on two items (i.e., “I felt isolated” and “I felt alone”; seven-point Likert scales; $\alpha = .87$), which confirmed that they felt relatively more isolated when the majority of newspaper evaluators were described as being from “la province” rather than from Paris ($M_{\text{Province}} = 2.51$, $M_{\text{Paris}} = 2.07$; $t(208) = 2.25$, $p < .05$). In other words, taking a survey that was purportedly administered to people who were less (vs. more) likely to share the same team affinity enhanced feelings of isolation.

Sponsorship advertisement. Next, respondents read the 16-page newspaper, which included six real advertisements (see the Web Appendix). One of the advertisements (on page 7) was from the French automobile brand Citroën, an actual sponsor of PSG. We manipulated sponsorship by showing either an unaltered version of a Citroën advertisement that referred to its sponsorship of PSG or an altered version that removed the PSG logo and the tagline mentioning its sponsorship of PSG (see Appendix A).

Sponsor brand recall. After reading the newspaper and providing open-ended feedback about the layout, respondents listed all the brands they could recall from the ads. We coded the Citroën ad as effective or not depending on brand recall (i.e., 1 = Citroën was listed as an advertiser, 0 = Citroën was not listed).

Alternative account based on identity salience. Because prior work has shown enhanced memory for identity-linked stimuli from identity salience generated by feeling distinct from others (Forehand, Deshpandé, and Reed 2002), we tested whether salience played a role in the effects observed. Respondents reported their identity salience in response to an open-ended question (“Please tell us about yourself in your own words. Please take one minute to do so”) and two seven-point items (“At this moment, to what extent are you thinking about you being a fan of the PSG?” and “At this moment, to what extent are you considering yourself a fan of PSG?”) anchored by “not at all” and “very much” ($\alpha = .95$; adapted from Reed 2004). Fan isolation and the interaction between fan isolation and identification did not correspond to either identity salience measure ($ps > .23$).

Study 2a: Results

Considering the dichotomous performance outcome (brand recall) and the 2 (fan isolation: more vs. less isolated) $\times$ 2 (sponsorship: present vs. absent) $\times$ continuous(identification) design, we submitted sponsor brand recall (1/0) to a logistic

² The research firm screened for fans of PSG by asking potential respondents “In which sports are you interested?” and then, if they answered soccer (football), asking them to list the team they were a fan of; if they identified the PSG, they were asked to complete Cameron’s (2004) scale to assess their level of fan identification. We instructed the firm to focus on fans living outside Paris to enhance the efficacy of the isolation manipulation.

Table 3. Studies 2a and 2b Estimation Results: Recall of Citroën Advertisement.

	Study 2a: Ad with or Without Sponsorship			Study 2b: One or Two Exposures to Ad with Sponsorship		
	Estimate		p-Value	Estimate		p-Value
Primary Predictors						
Advertisement condition (Ad)	2.26	(.79)	.004	-.21	(.65)	.741
Identification	1.67	(.48)	<.001	1.34	(.33)	<.001
Isolation	1.72	(.85)	.043	1.29	(.59)	.029
Identification × Isolation	1.51	(.56)	.007	1.12	(.41)	.007
Identification × Ad	1.74	(.53)	.001	1.20	(.45)	.007
Isolation × Ad	2.71	(1.04)	.009	1.27	(.86)	.140
Identification × Isolation × Ad	1.82	(.68)	.007	1.28	(.57)	.030
Controls						
Age	.01	(.01)	.228	.02	(.01)	.030
Gender (Female)	-.75	(.31)	.017	-.48	(.30)	.111
Intercept	1.81	(.84)	.031	.88	(.62)	.155
Model Fit						
Deviance (−2 log likelihood)	254.7			316.9		
AIC	274.7			336.9		
BIC	308.2			373.7		
Likelihood ratio chi-square test	35.49 (df = 9)			62.88 (df = 9)		
	<.001			<.001		

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses. Isolation, identification, and advertisement conditions are shifted so 0 = the isolated condition, one exposure to the advertisement with sponsorship, and one standard deviation above mean levels of identification, which displays the estimated effect of each direct effect and two-way interactions at a meaningful 0 point for the other variable.

regression with fan isolation, identification, sponsorship, and their interaction as predictors (see Table 3). The three-way interaction of isolation, identification, and sponsorship was significant ($b = 1.82, p < .01$). In support of H_1 , when the Citroën ad featured the sponsorship of PSG, the interaction between fan isolation and identification was significant for recall of Citroën ($b = 1.51, p < .01$); neither factor mattered for the Citroën ad without the sponsorship of PSG. In the sponsorship ad conditions, we decomposed the isolation × identification interaction, using spotlight analyses (Spiller et al. 2013) of the simple effect of isolation at two levels of identification (± 1 standard deviation from the mean for strong and weak fans). Isolation increased the likelihood of recalling the Citroën ad among strong fans ($b = 1.72, p < .05$), in line with the doubling-down effect, but decreased this likelihood among weak fans ($b = -1.63, p < .05$), in line with the desertion effect. In other words, identification predicted likelihood to recall Citroën among more isolated fans ($b = 1.62, p < .001$) but not among less isolated fans. In the less isolated condition, recall was similar with or without sponsorship.

For a model-free illustration of sponsor brand performance, we grouped fans into stronger and weaker identification, using a median split (at 4.08), and then calculated the percentage of fans who recalled Citroën in each experimental condition (see Figure 3). In the sponsorship ad conditions (i.e., PSG team logo present), only 55% of strong fans recalled Citroën if they were less isolated, but recall jumped to 83% in the more isolated condition, in line with the doubling-down effect. For strong isolated fans, the recall percentage more than doubled, from 40% for the ad without sponsorship to 83% for the ad with

sponsorship, exhibiting the potential value of a well-targeted sponsorship advertisement. However, for weak fans, the pattern flipped to reveal a desertion effect, such that only 17% recalled Citroën from the ad with sponsorship in the more isolated condition, compared with 52% in the less isolated condition. This desertion effect is especially stark given that 55% of weak isolated fans recalled Citroën when the ad simply omitted sponsorship information. The collapse in recall implies that weak fans actively avoid vestiges of their fan identity that interfere with their efforts to affiliate with their more proximal social environment.

Study 2b: Method

We theorize that isolation stimulates affiliation motives that differentially affect team-linked recall by increasing strong (weak) fans' desire to seek (ignore) team-based sponsorship affiliation. Thus, isolated strong fans are simply paying more attention to brand sponsors. If this is valid, multiple exposures to brand sponsors should increase recall for all fans, which we test in Study 2b. Furthermore, Study 2b formally shows that our central predictions have strong managerial implications, in terms of media planning, by providing a comparison of the efficacies of a targeted, single ad and a repeated-exposure ad. Finally, Study 2b rules out alternative accounts based on mood (Pham 1992) or threat (Dalton and Huang 2014).

Other than these alternative accounts, the design was identical to that in Study 2a. The same market research firm recruited 386 PSG fans from "la province" (i.e., outside Paris) and measured fan identification ($\alpha = .84$). A week later, 293 of

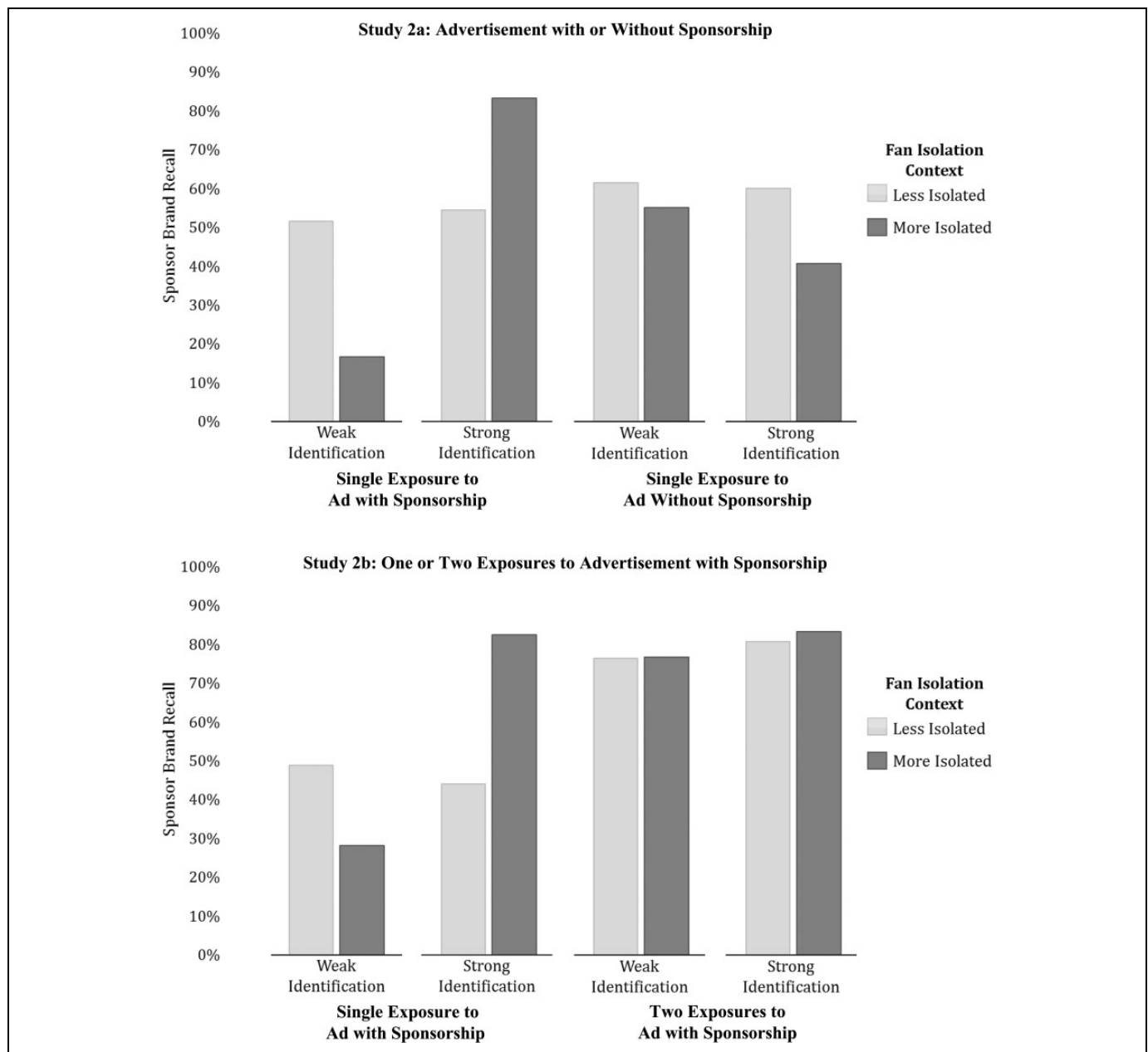


Figure 3. Studies 2a and 2b: Percentage of fans who recall the sponsor brand in each isolation $\times$ identification $\times$ sponsorship advertisement condition.

Notes: Grouping of fan identification is based on a median split for strong and weak fans at above or below 4.08 for Study 2a and 4.00 for Study 2b. Bar graphs represent the raw percentage of fans in each cell who correctly recalled the sponsor brand as an advertiser in an unaided recall task.

these informants completed the second survey (30.4% women, average age 44.59 years). The second survey included the same cover, randomly assigned fan isolation manipulation, and newspaper from Study 2a. The 16-page newspaper displayed the Citroën ad with its sponsorship of PSG either twice in the two-exposure condition (pages 7 and 13) or once in the single-exposure condition (page 7, with an ad for another brand on page 13). Respondents rated mood on a seven-point bipolar scale (“very negative/very positive”) and indicated their sense of feeling threatened (“unhappy/

threatened/attacked/maligned”) on seven-point scales (“not at all/very much”; $\alpha = .88$).

Study 2b: Results

This study was a 2 (fan isolation: more vs. less isolated) $\times$ 2 (ad exposure: one vs. two) $\times$ continuous (identification) design, and we submitted sponsor brand recall (1/0) to a logistic regression with isolation, identification, ad exposure, and their interaction as predictors (see Table 3). The three-way interaction of

isolation, identification, and ad exposures was significant ($b = 1.28, p < .05$). In support of H_1 , the interaction between isolation and identification in the single-exposure condition was significant ($b = 1.12, p < .01$), replicating the finding from Study 2a. However, neither factor mattered for respondents who saw the Citroën ad twice. Overall recall increased from 50% in the single-exposure condition to 79% in the two-exposure condition. Fan identification in response to isolation appears most influential at the point of encoding, suggesting that selective attention explains the effect. We also tested whether mood or a sense of being threatened might explain the influence of isolation but found no significant main effects on fan isolation or on the interaction between fan isolation and identification ($ps > .72$).

To understand the model-free impact of isolation across advertising conditions for strong and weak fans, we grouped fans into stronger and weaker identification categories, using a median split (at 4.00), and then calculated the percentage of strong and weak fans who recalled the Citroën ad in each condition (see Figure 3). For fans exposed to the sponsor-linked ad once, the results mimic the pattern from Study 2a. Weak fans display desertion behavior (recall of Citroën falls from 49% in the less isolated condition to 28% in the more isolated condition), and strong fans exhibit doubling-down behavior (recall jumps from 44% in the less isolated condition to 82% in the more isolated condition).

Discussion

Both Studies 2a and 2b provide experimental evidence of a doubling-down effect for strong fans and a desertion effect for weak fans in an isolated context. For brand managers, this doubling-down effect can even be taken literally; one exposure to the team-linked sponsorship ad performs as well as two exposures (82% and 83% recall) among strong fans in an isolated context. Thus, brand managers interested in improving awareness and recall should recognize isolated strong fans as efficient advertising targets.

In terms of understanding how fans respond to isolation, these studies support motivated encoding (or ignoring) of the sponsorship, consistent with an affiliation motive driving people's responses to isolation. We find no evidence to support alternative explanations based on identity salience, mood, or feeling threatened. Next, in Study 3 we aim to directly demonstrate the mediating role of affiliation motives and to show how a motivated response to sponsors translates into additional sponsorship performance outcomes.

Study 3: Examining Process Through a Quasi Experiment

In Study 3, we test the proposed process by which isolation creates an affiliation motivation, which can elicit greater interest in brand sponsors among strong fans but less interest among weak fans. Brands often engage in sponsorships in the hope of gaining favor among fans (Mazodier and Merunka 2012; Simmons and Becker-Olsen 2006), and therefore we measure sponsor brand performance as attitude toward the brand. The same

fan isolation $\times$ identification interaction pattern should emerge for attitude toward the brand if fans embrace or reject sponsor brands. Finally, Study 3 gives us the opportunity to test the viability of alternative explanations: identity salience (Forehand, Deshpandé, and Reed 2002), mood (Pham 1992), and feelings of threat (Dalton and Huang 2014).

Method

Sample and design. We recruited 578 U.S. adults from Amazon Mechanical Turk to take part in this study in exchange for a nominal fee. Respondents began the survey by indicating whether they were fans of a team in the NFL and then selected their favorite team and state of residence; only those who were fans of a team based in a state other than their state of residence were allowed to proceed.³ After screening, 227 respondents (101 women, median age of 32 years) entered the final sample. We used a 2 (fan isolation: more vs. less) $\times$ continuous (fan identification) design. Respondents first completed one of two writing tasks as a manipulation of fan isolation. Then, all respondents evaluated an online article that contained an embedded sponsorship advertisement, after which they completed several measures: affiliation motives, identity salience, brand sponsor attitudes, mood, threat, identification, and manipulation checks. Finally, respondents provided demographic information, including whether they owned the sponsoring brand, and were thanked for their efforts.

Fan isolation manipulation. To manipulate fan isolation, we told respondents that we were trying to “cultivate examples of how fans watch games in different surroundings,” so they needed to complete a writing task, with their favorite team name listed for [team]. We randomly assigned respondents to one of two conditions with a similar writing prompt; the text in *italics* appeared only in the more isolated experience condition; the text in parentheses appeared only in the less isolated experience condition.

As a fan of the [team], think about a time when you were watching a [team] game and everyone around you was *rooting for a different team* (also rooting for the [team]). What was it like to be so *distinct from* (similar to) other fans? How did you feel? Using the space below, describe this experience.

To ensure the manipulation took effect, toward the end of the survey, respondents rated how isolated they felt (“Describe how you felt during this study”) on three seven-point scales (1 = “in the majority,” and 7 = “in the minority”; 1 = “same as others,” and 7 = “different from others”; 1 = “part of the crowd,” and 7 = “an outcast”). The averaged scores ($\alpha = .85$) revealed that respondents assigned to the more isolated condition scored higher than those in the less isolated condition ($M_{\text{More}} = 4.07, M_{\text{Less}} = 3.11; t(225) = 5.64, p < .001$).

³ We recruited fans separated from their team to facilitate a stronger manipulation of experienced isolation. We lift this restriction in the extension described in Study 3.

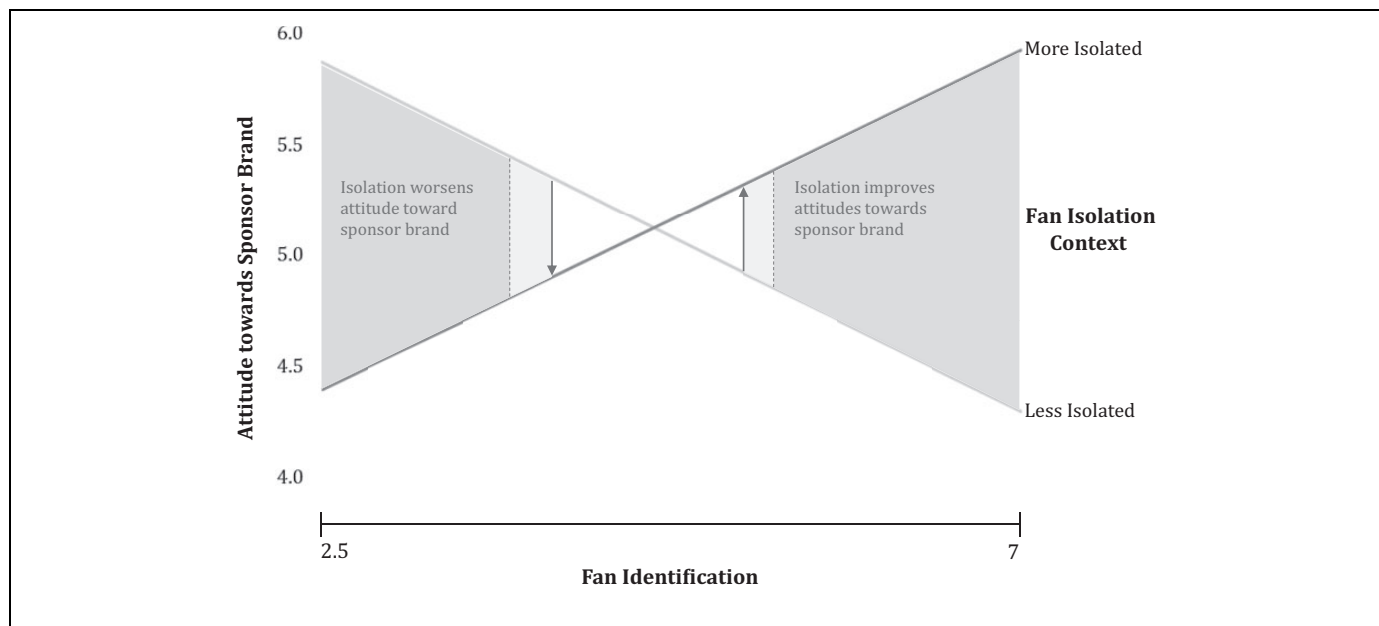


Figure 4. Study 3: Attitudes toward sponsor brand as a function of fan identification $\times$ isolation.

Notes: 2.5 was the minimum observed value for fan identification in this sample. Shading represents regions at which effect of isolation is significant at 90% (light gray) and 95% (dark gray) confidence levels.

We then asked respondents to proceed to an ostensibly separate task for which they read an article about the upcoming schedule for the 2016 NFL season and the first [divisional] game between the [team] and the [first divisional opponent of team]. We customized the team, division, and opponent names for each article. We told the respondents that we were seeking “insight into fans’ experience of reading about their favorite team.” The article was formatted as a Yahoo article, which allowed for several display ads to appear around it. The sponsorship ad appeared directly below the article, with a large logo for Chevrolet and the text “A proud supporter of the [team]” (see Appendix B). After reading the article, respondents provided open-ended feedback about their reading experience.

Respondents rated their affiliation motives (“When you described your experience watching a game of the [team], how did you feel?”) using five items measured on seven-point agreement scales ($\alpha = .86$): “I felt a strong desire to fit in with fellow [team] fans,” “I felt a need to belong to a [team] group of fans,” “Feeling a mutual connection with other [team] fans was important to me,” “I felt a strong desire to connect with other [team] fans,” and “I did not need to be a part of the group of [team] fans” (reversed).

Alternative accounts. Respondents rated their fan identity salience (“At this moment, to what extent are you thinking about your identity as a [team] fan?”) on a dichotomous scale (0 = “not at all,” 1 = “very much”) (Reed 2004). Then, they rated their mood on a 21-point scale (−10 = “very unpleasant,” and 10 = “very pleasant”) and also the extent to which they felt threatened (“unhappy/threatened/attacked/maligned/

challenged/impugned”) on seven-point scales (“not at all/very much”). We averaged the ratings ($\alpha = .89$).

Sponsor brand attitude. Next, respondents rated their attitudes toward seven automobile brands (“Rate your attitude toward the following brands”) on the same single-item seven-point scale (1 = “dislike a great deal,” 7 = “like a great deal”): the sponsor Chevrolet as well as Ford, Cadillac, Acura, Chrysler, Tesla, and Toyota.

Identification. Finally, respondents rated their level of fan identification using the same 12-item seven-point scale from the previous studies, adapted to their favorite NFL ($\alpha = .80$).

Results

Sponsor brand attitude. We regressed sponsor brand attitude on fan isolation, identification, and their interaction, which revealed a significant interaction ($b = .69, p < .01$). Floodlight analysis revealed that fan isolation had a positive and significant ($p < .05$) effect on attitude for strong fans in the top 19% of our sample (JN point at identification scores equal to or greater than 5.42). However, isolation led to less favorable attitudes toward the sponsor for relatively weak fans in the bottom 7% of our sample (JN point = 3.72) (see Figure 4). The interaction remained significant whether we controlled for age, gender, mood, Chevrolet ownership, or team fixed effects ($b = .55, p < .05$).

Affiliation motives and moderated mediation. Next, we examined whether this focal interaction between fan isolation and identification stems from how people deal with an increase in

affiliation motives under an isolating social situation. We began by confirming that fan isolation had a main effect on affiliation motives. An independent sample t-test of affiliation motive ratings revealed a significant main effect of fan isolation ($M_{\text{More}} = 3.80$, $M_{\text{Less}} = 3.21$; $t(225) = 3.57$, $p < .001$). Identification did not moderate the effect on affiliation motives in a regression ($p = .34$), nor did we find a significant main effect of isolation on identity salience, mood, threat, or any interactions with identification ($ps > .15$).

We conducted a moderated mediation analysis with affiliation motives using Hayes's (2018) PROCESS macro and bootstrapping procedures (model 15, 10,000 bootstrapped samples). We entered affiliation motives as the mediator of the effect of fan isolation (0 = more isolated, -1 = less isolated) on attitude toward the sponsor brand, with fan identification moderating how affiliation motives translate into attitudes toward the sponsor brand. In support of H₂ and consistent with the predicted process, the highest-order index of moderated mediation was significant (index = .133, standard error [SE] = .069; 95% CI = .03, .30). By decomposing this highest-order index, we found that the conditional indirect effect of fan isolation, mediated by affiliation motives, was positive when identification was strong (i.e., 90th percentile; effect = .158, SE = .099; 95% CI: .01, .40), but we observed the opposite pattern when identification was weak (i.e., 10th percentile), though this effect was only marginally significant with a 90% CI below 0 (effect = -.131, SE = .088; 90% CI: -.31, -.02). We found no statistical support for alternative models of mediation without moderation or with the key interaction on affiliation motives.

Discussion and Extension

Study 3 provides experimental evidence of the proposed affiliation motive process. It also extends the isolation $\times$ identification interaction to another sponsorship performance outcome—namely, attitude toward the sponsor brand. We observe an overall lift in attitudes toward the brand, as well as a lift relative to the brand's competitive set, for isolated strong fans who embrace the sponsor brand. Study 3 also offers further evidence that isolated weak fans desert a sponsor brand affiliated with their team.

To strengthen the managerial relevance of our framework, we repeated the experimental design in Study 3 with Chipotle as the brand sponsor of the respondents' favorite NFL team, with the sponsorship displayed at the bottom of an ESPN article about the team (for stimuli, see Appendix C). At the end of the survey, as a "thank you," we entered respondents into a raffle for one of two \$20 gift cards. Respondents indicated their preference for Chipotle or Panera Bread, Chipotle's closest fast-casual competitor (Oyedele 2017). One hundred sixty-three U.S. adults recruited from Amazon Mechanical Turk took part in this study. Six responses originating from the same IP address were dropped, leaving a final sample of 157 respondents (76 women, median age of 33 years). We submitted choice of sponsor brand (1/0) to a logistic regression with fan

isolation, identification, and their interaction as predictors. The results revealed a marginally significant interaction ($b = .71$, $p = .066$). Decomposing this interaction, we found that fan isolation had a positive, significant effect ($p < .05$) on choice of the sponsor brand among the strongest 54% of fans in the sample (JN point = 5.05). The estimated probability of a strong fan choosing the brand sponsor's gift card was 67% in the isolated condition but only 35% in the less isolated condition. This extension to a behavioral outcome demonstrates the potential value of sponsorship driving strong fans through the purchase funnel more effectively in isolating contexts.

General Discussion

Three sets of studies involving 1,412 real-life sports fans across multiple sports (soccer, basketball, and football), countries (United Kingdom, United States, and France), and methods (field surveys and quasi experiments) demonstrate that fan isolation and identification jointly determine how receptive fans are to sponsorship and, thus, sponsorship performance. This research sheds light on how contextual factors shape advertising effectiveness (Kumar and Gupta 2016). Drawing on identity and affiliation theories (Ethier and Deaux 1994; Mehra, Kilduff, and Bass 1998), we find that isolation from the team community generates an affiliation motive, but this motive triggers different responses depending on the strength of fans' identification. In isolating contexts, fans with strong identities "double down" and embrace team-linked brands. We show that sponsor brand performance is much higher for strong fans in more than less isolating contexts, as indicated by the 46% better unaided recall, 38% more favorable attitudes, 39% higher purchase intentions, 43% higher WOM, and 91% greater likelihood to choose the brand sponsor instead of a competitor. Conversely, isolation hurts brand performance for weak fans. These findings extend theory and provide useful managerial insights.

Theoretical Implications

Broadening the scope of sponsorship theory. Extant research on sponsor performance at the fan level has examined the importance of team proximity to brands and fans (Collins et al. 2016; DeSarbo, Blank, and Kim 2017; Woisetschlager, Backhaus, and Cornwell 2017). Other research has established fan identification as a key driver of sponsor performance (e.g., Grohs 2016; Madrigal 2000). The current research bridges these two strands of literature to understand the contingent nature of both fan isolation and identification.

As an initial examination of how social context interacts with fan characteristics to shape sponsorship performance, we build a theory of fan affiliation for out-of-market sponsorship. Prior work on cultural identity, mobility, and affiliation explains the cultural activities people adopt or avoid in novel social contexts (Ethier and Deaux 1994). With an analogous process pertaining to fans in relation to team communities, the affiliation lens predicts how strong and weak fans will

differentially respond to brand sponsors depending on the level of social isolation.

Differentiating strong from weak fans. Prior research that demonstrates the impact of sources of a shared identity on consumers generally considers domains in which identity is uniformly strong (Berger and Heath 2008; White and Dahl 2006). Our work highlights the critical role of varying levels of identification across consumers with the same shared identity. Fans differ in how enduring, chronically salient, and emotionally significant their fan identification is to their sense of self. Ostensibly, all fans of a team should favor team sponsors in all circumstances; however, we show that isolation triggers different affiliation strategies depending on the level of identification, highlighting critical differences that exist among strong and weak fans. Dichotomizing identity into members and nonmembers (fans and nonfans) would hide the opposing effects of isolation across members of varying levels of identification.

Managerial Implications

This research offers new insights for branding and advertising efforts that aim to build connections with consumers around points of passion. Managerial interest in sponsorship is growing because sponsorship provides mass-market visibility in a fragmenting media environment (Thompson 2016), and technology is improving not only the precision of sponsor targeting but also the measurement of sponsorship effectiveness (Jensen and Cobbs 2014). Our framework suggests that by successfully targeting strong fans in isolating contexts, managers can achieve performance outcomes with a single advertisement that are comparable to those of multiple ad exposures (Study 2b). This finding adds to the growing body of research on targeted advertising. For example, Ma and Sun (2016) suggest that greater involvement in entertainment activities significantly reduces consumers' interest in mobile in-app advertisements. Given that isolation can be a transitory experience, we show that managers can selectively target strong fans when they are isolated.

Local brands that sponsor local teams should keep in mind that weak fans are equally receptive as strong fans. Thus, local sponsors should not narrowly target strong fans or use overly nuanced promotional messaging that weak fans might fail to comprehend. Overall, our findings justify the \$560 million sponsorship of Manchester United by Chevrolet, despite criticisms (Baxter 2014). Chevrolet had global ambitions in choosing its sponsorship, and our findings indicate that teams with many isolated fans (e.g., Manchester United, the Lakers) should be attractive to global brands even if the sponsorship falls flat in local markets.

Managerial Implementation

To demonstrate how brand managers armed with the power of social media can target audiences on the basis of interest and

location, we created Facebook ads for "Boon," a fictitious brand appearing as a sponsor for the two teams playing in the 2018 Super Bowl (for the ads, targeting, and further details, see Appendix D). Through Facebook's targeting settings, we delivered the ads to people residing in each team's home market, who should experience little isolation, or those in Texas, a neutral, out-of-market context. We then selected items such as "Away from hometown" for more isolation with "Demographics > Life Events." We used interest in the NFL team to identify strong fans, and we identified weak fans as those with interest in the team's city but not explicitly in the team, because identification with a city is a driver of fan identification (Collins et al. 2016). The performance of the ads, based on clicks per ad, was consistent with our empirical studies; strong fans outside the team's market had 8% more clicks than strong fans inside the team's market. Yet the same number of clicks was generated from all people in the team's market regardless of fan identification. Isolated weak fans, however, had 26% fewer clicks than weak fans in the team's market. Although these findings are preliminary, they illustrate how managers can implement the framework. In summary, sponsor brands should consider promoting their sponsorship to all consumers in the team's home market regardless of fandom while also promoting it to strong fans out-of-market using interest- and location-based targeting.

Limitations and Avenues for Research

This research is not without limitations, several of which deserve attention. First, we only examined fans' reception to current sponsors or held the brand constant; we did not examine brand-specific factors, such as the effects of fit between the sports team and the sponsor or the degree to which a brand sponsors many teams. We show that proximity to or isolation from the fan community is relevant for fans' acceptance of sponsors; the proximity of the brand to the team is also relevant for fans' acceptance of sponsors (Woisetschl ger, Backhaus, and Cornwell 2017). Several brand-related factors may alter attributions for sponsorship and thus affect how willing even strong isolated fans are to embrace the sponsor. Therefore, it is worth testing whether fans' acceptance of poorly fitting sponsors is conditional on their location or characteristics of the brand. Furthermore, a brand sponsor with a limited geographic footprint may lack relevance for distant fans.

Second, we do not examine antecedents determining variance in fan identification. Further research should take a dynamic perspective to determine how identification evolves in light of greater isolation, to provide insights to managers trying to grow the number of strong isolated fans. Understanding the evolution of identification is of wide interest in sports marketing (Lock et al. 2012), but managers might face challenges when trying to cultivate strong isolated fans because of factors such as competition from other teams or fan difficulties in viewing games. Once cultivated, however, isolated strong

fans may become especially valuable advocates because of the need to justify their support to themselves and others.

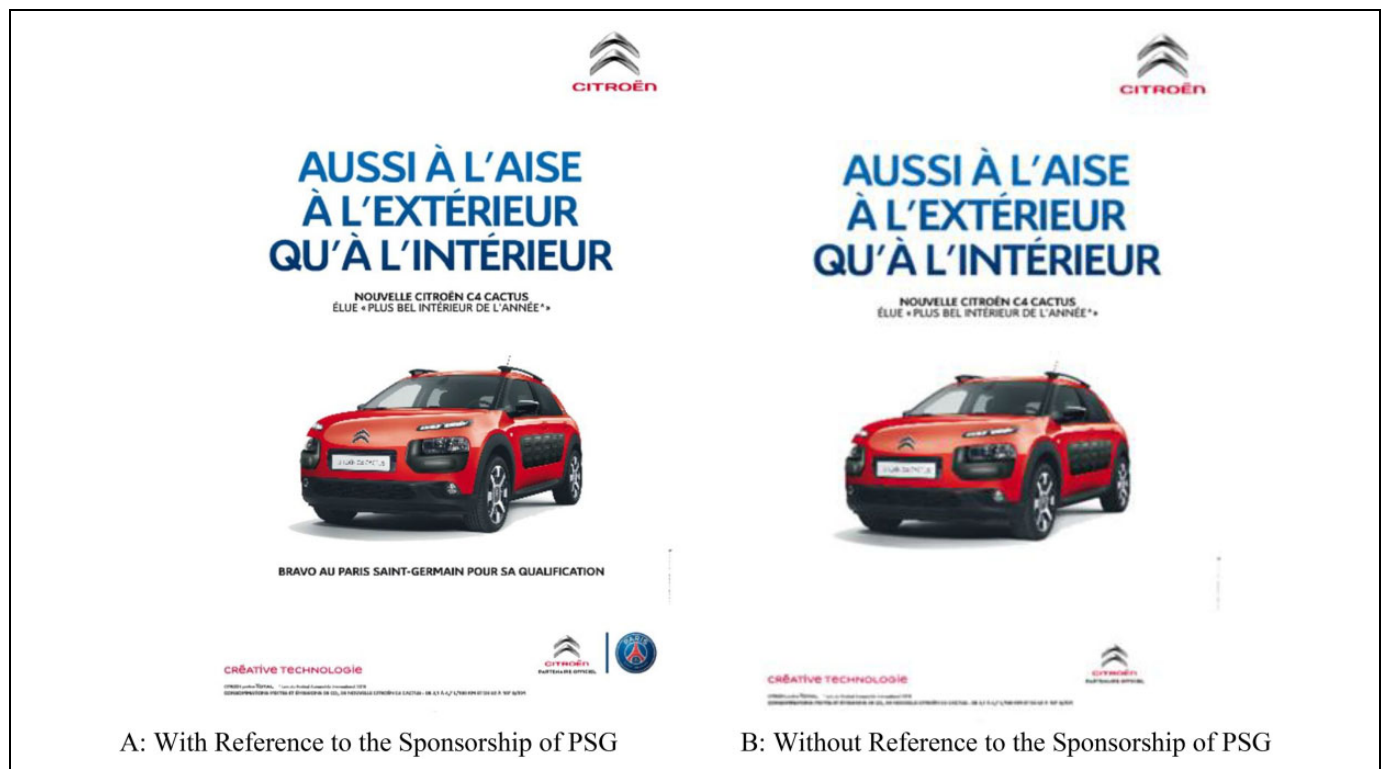
Third, further research is required to develop techniques to assess when experiences of isolation arise (e.g., does watching a team play an away game at another team's stadium create a temporary experience of isolation?) and for whom identification is strong through observable behavior (e.g., time spent viewing team-related posts, number of hours spent on the team website, tickets bought online). Summers, Smith, and Reczek (2016) demonstrate the importance of measurement accuracy for behavior-based advertising targeting. Advertisement platforms such as Facebook and Google offer detailed information on online behavior and location, and connecting these data with fan identification would unlock powerful targeting opportunities.

Fourth, we adopted a broad view of fan identification as a starting point to investigate its interplay with isolation, but further research could expand on the nuances in the main object of fans' identification. For example, by construction, our focal measure of fan identification was broad and included both cognitive and affective elements (Cameron 2004). The focal effects

were robust to an alternative, more cognitive measure of identification (Study 1b), but isolation may have different effects for cognitive versus affective identification. For example, perhaps the tendency for isolated weak fans to actively ignore brand sponsors is a form of emotionally based coping. Furthermore, strong fans usually dislike sponsors of rival teams (Bergkvist 2012; Grohs, Reisinger, and Woisetschlager 2015). Research could test whether isolated strong fans still react positively to their team's sponsors when those brands also support a rival team. If not, sponsors could benefit from rivalry games that amplify isolation (Berendt, Uhrich, and Thompson 2018).

Last, we focused on professional sponsorship, but brands also sponsor local teams and grassroots sports clubs (Plewa et al. 2016). Grassroots teams are less likely to have out-of-market fans, but fans may feel isolated in different social situations. Further research might explore whether our framework extends to these contexts. In conclusion, research on the interplay between consumers' interests and social context deserves more attention, especially as mobile technology and social media platforms empower marketers with greater information about both.

Appendix A.



Appendix A. Study 2: Sponsorship Advertising Stimuli.

Appendix C.

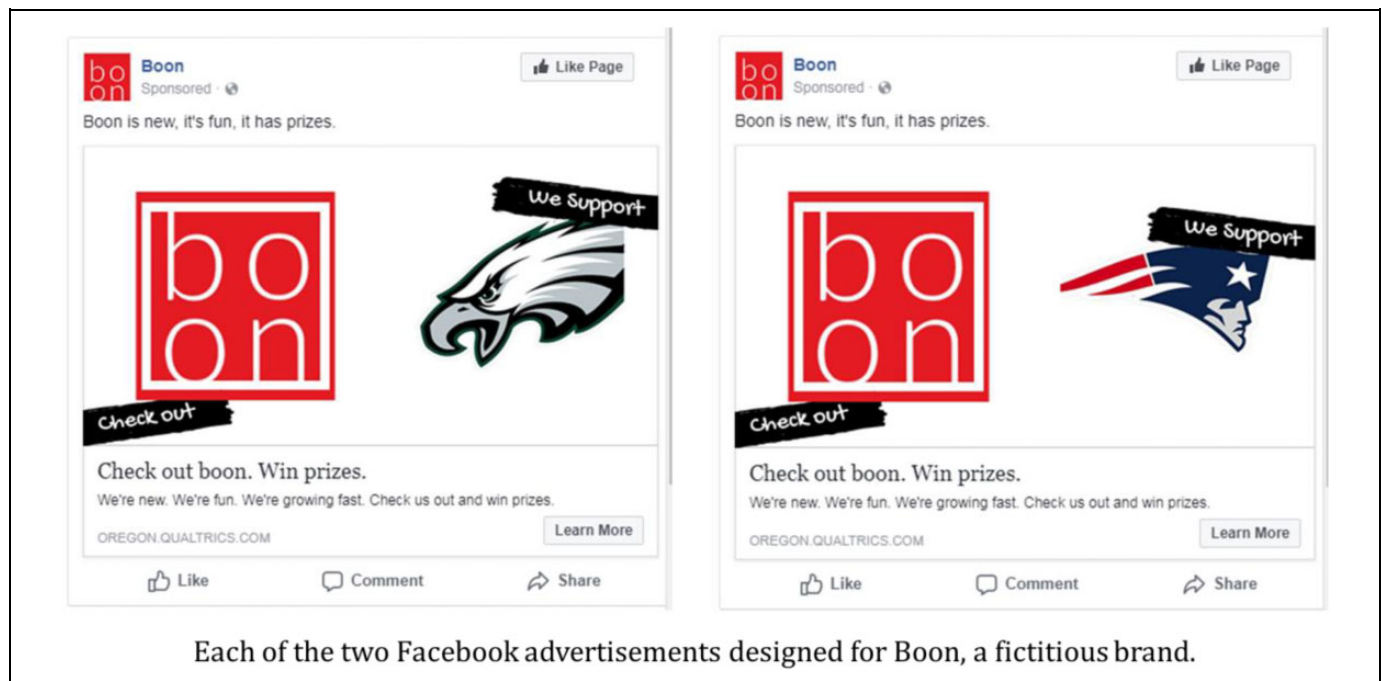
The screenshot shows the ESPN NFL Power Rankings for Week 17. The page is titled "Week 17 NFL Power Rankings: All 32 teams vs. their projected win totals" and is dated "2d - ESPN.com". The left sidebar contains several articles, including "From face of the franchise to the enemy: Athletes who have made jarring jersey changes" and "NFL Playoff Picture: Updated seeds after Week 16". The main content area lists the top 8 teams. The 6th ranked team is the New Orleans Saints with a 2017 record of 11-4 and a Week 16 ranking of No. 7. The 7th ranked team is the Carolina Panthers with a 2017 record of 11-4 and a Week 16 ranking of No. 8. The 8th ranked team is the Kansas City Chiefs with a 2017 record of 9-6 and a Week 16 ranking of No. 10. The Chiefs' entry mentions that after a 5-0 start, it seems pretty crazy that they might not surpass nine wins, and lists players Alex Smith, Kareem Hunt, Tyreek Hill, and Travis Kelce. At the bottom, the Kansas City Chiefs logo and the Chipotle Mexican Grill logo are displayed with the text "Proud Sponsor of the Chiefs".

Appendix C. Example of Stimuli for Study 3's Extension to Choice as an Objective Performance Outcome.

Appendix D.

We distributed ads for each team the day before the team appeared in the Super Bowl. We spent \$60 promoting each advertisement. We targeted four audiences for each of the Eagles ad and the Patriots ad, as follows:

- Isolation
 - High: Location in state of Texas (neutral market) and Demographics > Life Events > "Away from family," "Away from hometown," or "Recently moved"
 - Low: In team market: 50-mile radius of Philadelphia (or Boston for Patriots)
- Fan identification
 - Strong fans: Interests > Additional Interests > "Philadelphia Eagles" ("New England Patriots")
 - Weak fans: Interests > Additional Interests > "Philadelphia" ("Boston") and Exclude People > Additional Interests > "Philadelphia Eagles" ("New England Patriots")



Appendix D. Advertisements for Managerial Implementation Demonstration.

Acknowledgment

The authors acknowledge Bettina Cornwell for her helpful feedback on a previous version of this article.

Author Contributions

The authors contributed equally and appear in reverse alphabetical order.

Area Editor

Robert Meyer served as area editor for this article.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author(s) disclosed receipt of the following financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article: This research was partially funded by the Business School of Hong Kong Baptist University and the Warsaw Sports Marketing Center at the University of Oregon.

References

- Andrews, Michelle, Xueming Luo, Zheng Fang, and Anindya Ghose (2016), "Mobile Ad Effectiveness: Hyper-Contextual Targeting with Crowdedness," *Marketing Science*, 35 (2), 218–33.
- Baumeister, Roy F., and Mark R. Leary (1995), "The Need to Belong: Desire for Interpersonal Attachments as a Fundamental Human Motivation," *Psychological Bulletin*, 117 (3), 497–529.
- Baxter, Kevin (2014), "Manchester United Uniform Is Pricey Real Estate, as Chevrolet Knows," *Los Angeles Times*, <http://www.latimes.com/sports/soccer/la-sp-manchester-united-20140722-story.html>.
- Berendt, Johannes, Sebastian Uhrich, and Scott A. Thompson (2018), "Marketing, Get Ready to Rumble—How Rivalry Promotes Distinctiveness for Brands and Consumers," *Journal of Business Research*, 88 (July), 161–172.
- Bergami, Massimo, and Richard P. Bagozzi (2000), "Self-Categorization, Affective Commitment, and Group Self-Esteem as Distinct Aspects of Social Identity in the Organization," *British Journal of Social Psychology*, 39 (4), 555–77.
- Berger, Jonah, and Chip Heath (2008), "Who Drives Divergence? Identity Signaling, Outgroup Dissimilarity, and the Abandonment of Cultural Tastes," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 95 (3), 593–607.
- Bergkvist, Lars (2012), "The Flipside of the Sponsorship Coin: Do You Still Buy the Beer When the Brewer Underwrites a Rival Team?" *Journal of Advertising Research*, 52 (1), 65–73.
- Cacioppo, John T., James H. Fowler, and Nicholas A. Christakis (2009), "Alone in the Crowd: The Structure and Spread of Loneliness in a Large Social Network," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 97 (6), 977–91.
- Cameron, James (2004), "A Three Factor Model of Social Identity," *Self and Identity*, 3 (3), 239–62.
- Collins, Dorothy R., Bob Heere, Stephen Shapiro, Lynn Ridinger, and Henry Wear (2016), "The Displaced Fan: The Importance of New Media and Community Identification for Maintaining Team Identity with Your Hometown Team," *European Sport Management Quarterly*, 16 (5), 655–74.
- Cornwell, T. Bettina, Michael S. Humphreys, Angela M. Maguire, Clinton S. Weeks, and Cassandra L. Tellegen (2006),

- "Sponsorship-Linked Marketing: The Role of Articulation in Memory," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 33 (3), 312–21.
- Cornwell, T. Bettina, Clinton S. Weeks, and Donald P. Roy (2005), "Sponsorship-Linked Marketing: Opening the Black Box," *Journal of Advertising*, 34 (2), 21–42.
- Dalton, Amy, and Huang Li (2014), "Motivated Forgetting in Response to Social Identity Threat," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 40 (2), 1017–38.
- Decrop, Alain, and Christian Derbaix (2010), "Pride in Contemporary Sport Consumption: A Marketing Perspective," *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 38 (5), 586–603.
- DeSarbo, Wayne S., Ashley Stadler Blank, and Sunghoon Kim (2017), "Sports Diaspora: A National Survey of NFL Fan Dispersion," *Sports Business Journal*, 20 (26), 26.
- Ethier, Kathleen A., and Kay Deaux (1994), "Negotiating Social Identity When Contexts Change: Maintaining Identification and Responding to Threat," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 67 (2), 243–51.
- Fain, Irving (2013), "Displaced Fans Remain Connected – and Valuable – to Teams," *Sports Business Journal*, (February 4), <https://www.sportsbusinessdaily.com/Journal/Issues/2013/02/04/Opinion/From-the-Field-of-Fan-Engagement.aspx>.
- Forehand, Mark R., Rohit Deshpand, and Americus Reed II (2002), "Identity Salience and the Influence of Differential Activation of the Social Self-Schema on Advertising Response," *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 87 (6), 1086–99.
- Funk, Daniel C., Lynn L. Ridinger, and Anita J. Moorman (2004), "Exploring the Origins of Involvement: Understanding the Relationship Between Consumer Motives and Involvement with Professional Sport Teams," *Leisure Sciences*, 26 (1), 35–61.
- Grohs, Reinhard (2016), "Drivers of Brand Image Improvement in Sports-Event Sponsorship," *International Journal of Advertising*, 35 (3), 391–420.
- Grohs, Reinhard, Heribert Reisinger, and David M. Woisetschlager (2015), "Attenuation of Negative Sponsorship Effects in the Context of Rival Sports Teams' Fans," *European Journal of Marketing*, 49 (11/12), 1880–1901.
- Gwinner, Kevin P., and John Eaton (1999), "Building Brand Image Through Event Sponsorship: The Role of Image Transfer," *Journal of Advertising*, 28 (4), 47–57.
- Hayes, Andrew F. (2018), "Introduction to Mediation, Moderation, and Conditional Process Analysis Second Edition: A Regression-based Approach," (2nd edition). New York, NY: Ebook The Guilford Press.
- Herrmann, Jean-Luc, Mathieu Kacha, and Christian Derbaix (2016), "'I Support Your Team, Support Me in Turn!' The Driving Role of Consumers' Affiliation with the Sponsored Entity in Explaining Behavioral Effects of Sport Sponsorship Leveraging Activities," *Journal of Business Research*, 69 (2), 604–612.
- Hirt, Edward R., Dolf Zillmann, Grant A. Erickson, and Chris Kennedy (1992), "Costs and Benefits of Allegiance: Changes in Fans' Self-Ascribed Competencies After Team Victory Versus Defeat," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 63 (5), 724–38.
- IEG (2017), "Sponsorship Spending Forecast: Continued Growth around the World," IEG Sponsorship Report, (January 4), (accessed March 21, 2017), <http://www.sponsorship.com/iegsr/2017/01/04/Sponsorship-Spending-Forecast-Continued-Growth-Ar.aspx>.
- Jacobs, Jeff, Pallav Jain, and Kushan Surana (2014), "Is Sports Sponsorship Worth It?" McKinsey & Co., (June 14), <http://www.mckinsey.com/business-functions/marketing-and-sales/our-insights/is-sports-sponsorship-worth-it>.
- Jensen, Jonathan A., and Joe B. Cobbs (2014), "Predicting Return on Investment in Sport Sponsorship: Modeling Brand Exposure, Price, and ROI in Formula One Automotive Competition," *Journal of Advertising Research*, 54 (4), 435–47.
- Kumar, V., and Shaphali Gupta (2016), "Conceptualizing the Evolution and Future of Advertising," *Journal of Advertising*, 45 (3), 302–17.
- Lastovicka, John L., and Nancy J. Sirianni (2011), "Truly, Madly, Deeply: Consumers in the Throes of Material Possession Love," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 38 (2), 323–42.
- Lings, Ian N., and Kate M. Owen (2007), "Buying a Sponsor's Brand: The Role of Affective Commitment to the Sponsored Team," *Journal of Marketing Management*, 23 (5/6), 483–96.
- Lock, Daniel, Tracy Taylor, Daniel Funk, and Simon Darcy (2012), "Exploring the Development of Team Identification," *Journal of Sport Management*, 26 (4), 283–94.
- Ma, Liye, and Baohong Sun, (2016), "An Integrated Analysis of Mobile Application Usage and In-App Advertising Response," Marketing Science Institute Working Paper Series.
- Madrigal, Robert (2000), "The Influence of Social Alliances with Sports Teams on Intentions to Purchase Corporate Sponsors' Products," *Journal of Advertising*, 29 (4), 13–24.
- Mael, Fred, and Blake E. Ashforth (1992), "Alumni and Their Alma Mater: A Partial Test of the Reformulated Model of Organizational Identification," *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, 13 (2), 103–23.
- Marketing Science Institute (2016), *2016–2018 Research Priorities*. Cambridge, MA: Marketing Science Institute.
- Mazodier, Marc, and Dwight Merunka (2012), "Achieving Brand Loyalty Through Sponsorship: The Role of Fit and Self-Congruity," *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 40 (6), 807–20.
- Mazodier, Marc, and Amir Rezaee (2013), "Are Sponsorship Announcements Good News for the Shareholders? Evidence from International Stock Exchanges," *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 41 (5), 586–600.
- Mead, Nicole L., Roy F. Baumeister, Tyler F. Stillman, Catherine D. Rawn, and Kathleen D. Vohs (2011), "Social Exclusion Causes People to Spend and Consume Strategically in the Service of Affiliation," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 37 (5), 902–19.
- Mehra, Ajay, Martin Kilduff, and Daniel J. Brass (1998), "At the Margins: A Distinctiveness Approach to the Social Identity and Social Networks of Underrepresented Groups," *Academy of Management Journal*, 41 (4), 441–52.
- Meyners, Jannik, Christian Barrot, Jan U. Becker, and Jacob Goldenberg (2017), "The Role of Mere Closeness: How Geographic Proximity Affects Social Influence," *Journal of Marketing*, 81 (5), 49–66.

- Oishi, Shigehiro, Alexander J. Rothman, Mark Snyder, Jenny Su, Keri Zehm, Andrew W. Hertel, et al. (2007), "The Socioecological Model of Procommunity Action: The Benefits of Residential Stability," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 93 (5), 831–44.
- Oyedele, Akin (2017), "Chipotle's Biggest Competitor Is a Soup-and-Sandwich Chain," *Business Insider*, (March 29), <http://www.businessinsider.com/chipotle-competition-panera-bread-2017-3>.
- Oyserman, Daphna (2008), "Racial-Ethnic Self-Schemas: Multidimensional Identity-Based Motivation," *Journal of Research in Personality*, 42 (5), 1186–98.
- Pham, M. Tuan (1992), "Effects of Involvement, Arousal and Pleasure on the Recognition of Sponsorship Stimuli," in *Advances in Consumer Research*, Vol. 19, John F. Sherry Jr., and Brian Sternthal, eds. Provo, UT: Association for Consumer Research, 85–93.
- Plewa, Carolin, François A. Carrillat, Marc Mazodier, and Pascale G. Quester (2016), "Which Sport Sponsorships Most Impact Sponsor CSR Image?" *European Journal of Marketing*, 50 (5/6), 796–815.
- Pratt, Michael G. (1998), "To Be or not to Be: Central Questions in Organizational Identification," in *Identity in Organizations: Building Theory Through Conversations*, David A. Whetten and Paul C. Godfrey, eds. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 171–207.
- Premier League (2012), "Percentage of Global TV Audience of the Barclays Premier League 2011/12," Statista: The Statistics Portal, (accessed March 28, 2018), <https://www.statista.com/statistics/240891/geographical-distribution-of-global-premier-league-tv-audience/>.
- Pu, Haozhou, and Jeffrey James (2017), "The Distant Fan Segment: Exploring Motives and Psychological Connection of International National Basketball Association Fans," *International Journal of Sports Marketing and Sponsorship*, 18 (4), 418–38.
- Reed, Americus II (2004), "Activating the Self-Importance of Consumer Selves: Exploring Identity Salience Effects on Judgments," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 31 (2), 286–95.
- Reysen, Stephen, and Nyla R. Branscombe (2010), "Fanship and Fandom: Comparisons Between Sport and Non-Sport Fans," *Journal of Sport Behavior*, 33 (2), 176–93.
- Scheinbaum, Angeline Close, Anjala Krishen, and Nancy Lough (2017), "Event Word of Mouth: An Abstract," in *Creating Marketing Magic and Innovative Future Marketing Trends: Proceedings of the 2016 Academy of Marketing Science (AMS) Annual Conference*, Maximilian Stieler, ed. Cham: Springer, 695–96.
- Simmons, Carolyn J., and Karen L. Becker-Olsen (2006), "Achieving Marketing Objectives through Social Sponsorships," *Journal of Marketing*, 70 (4), 154–69.
- Spanberg, Erik (2012), "The challenge: Stand out amid the clutter," <https://www.sportsbusinessdaily.com/Journal/Issues/2012/03/26/In-Depth/Clutter.aspx> (in *Sports Business Journal*-March 26).
- Spiller, Stephen A., Gavan J. Fitzsimons, John G. Lynch, and Gary H. McClelland (2013), "Spotlights, Floodlights, and the Magic Number Zero: Simple Effects Tests in Moderated Regression," *Journal of Marketing Research*, 50 (2), 277–88.
- Stavros, Constantino, Matthew D. Meng, Kate Westberg, and Francis Farrelly (2014), "Understanding Fan Motivation for Interacting on Social Media," *Sport Management Review*, 17 (4), 455–69.
- Summers, Christopher A., Robert W. Smith, and Rebecca Walker Reczek (2016), "An Audience of One: Behaviorally Targeted Ads as Implied Social Labels," *Journal of Consumer Research*, 43 (1), 156–78.
- Tajfel, Henri, and John C. Turner (1979), "The Social Identity Theory of Intergroup Behavior," in *Psychology of Intergroup Relations*, Stephen Worchel and William G. Austin, eds. Chicago: Nelson Hall, 33–47.
- Thompson, Ben (2016), "The Sports Linchpin," (accessed August 17, 2017), <https://stratichery.com/2016/the-sports-linchpin/>.
- Wakefield, Kirk L., Karen Becker-Olsen, and T. Bettina Cornwell (2007), "I Spy a Sponsor: The Effects of Sponsorship Level, Prominence, Relatedness, and Cueing on Recall Accuracy," *Journal of Advertising*, 36 (4), 61–74.
- Walraven, Merel, Tammo H.A. Bijmolt, and Ruud H. Koning (2014), "Dynamic Effects of Sponsoring: How Sponsorship Awareness Develops over Time," *Journal of Advertising*, 43 (2), 142–54.
- White, Katherine, and Darren W. Dahl (2006), "To Be or Not Be? The Influence of Dissociative Reference Groups on Consumer Preferences," *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 16 (4), 404–14.
- Woisetschlager, David M., Christof Backhaus, and T. Bettina Cornwell (2017), "Inferring Corporate Motives: How Deal Characteristics Shape Sponsorship Perceptions," *Journal of Marketing*, 81 (5), 121–41.

Copyright of Journal of Marketing is the property of American Marketing Association and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.